

RAHUL GANDHI TOTES A SLIM LITTLE RED BOOK ON STAGE THESE DAYS. It's the Constitution of India—the coat pocket edition of Eastern Book Company familiar to young lawyers. Holding it up, the Congress leader, who turns 54 exactly 15 days after the Lok Sabha results come out on June 4, vows to protect it. His language is an ingenious mix of the late Kanshi Ram and the Occupy movement—two sources that seem unlikely only at first glance. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, blending gravity of tone with animated emphasis like only he can, mouths his own refrain these days. "I'll protect the Constitution with my life," as he said in his INDIA TODAY interview on May 17. Why are the two opposite sides, locked in mortal combat in a hotly contested election, promising the same thing? It's to do with something contained in that book, and what its author, B.R. Ambedkar, did through his life of ideas: a new politicisation of caste through affirmative action, or reservations.

The word 'caste'—and its long shadow, reservations—often appear on the public stage with visible discomfiture. General Election 2024 is turning out to be the third great exception to that, after the Mandal era disrupted that old order a second time after Ambedkar. Perhaps it marks a tectonic shift of equal magnitude. India's oldest party, the Congress, is going into the election with the promise of a national caste census as its primary campaign plank—to ensure reservations based on the population of the needy. It has for company two Mandal legatee parties—the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD)—promising to abolish the 50 per cent judicial ceiling on reservations in jobs and education. For the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Modi, seeking a third consecutive majority, the current Lok Sabha polls were to be the 'Ram' election, with the temple at Ayodhya as the stage prop for a renewed—and unproblematic—consecration of Hindutva. Instead, it was handed a forced detour into unpleasant territory by the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), verging on topics like jobs and economic distress. Religion, intersecting with everything in India, offered a refuge—and it must have seemed almost like divine intervention when the Calcutta High Court, on May 22, annulled

WHERE THEY ST

NDA

BJP: Party manifesto claims 60 per cent of current ministers are from OBC, SC/ST communities

↘ Instituted 10 per cent reservation for EWS (economically weaker sections)

↘ Home minister Amit Shah says the BJP will not remove reservations for SCs, STs and OBCs, calling it a "Modi guarantee"

↘ On April 28, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, who has in the past reflected the parent organisation's old stand on reservation, clarified that it now favours reservation for SCs, STs and OBCs as long as there is discrimination

JD(U): Bihar CM and JD(U) boss Nitish Kumar clinched a major win in November last year when the state assembly unanimously passed a Bill raising the quantum of reservation for SCs, EBCs, BCs and STs, based on the findings of the caste census conducted by the then Mahagathbandhan regime

↘ With this, the overall reservation in government jobs and state-run educational institutions went up to 75 per cent. This includes the 10 per cent for the EWS in the general category